DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

Does Everything in the World Depend on Israel?

Derech Hashem 2:4:8-9

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 2, Chapter 4, paragraphs 8 (end) and 9, and Chapter 5, paragraphs 1-2 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Monday 5 July 2021

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Review: Israel, the nations and the sar

The Rabbi summarised the chapter. The Jewish people descend from Avraham, the only one who returned to the level of Adam before the sin and became the root. At Sinai the nations had another chance and missed it, so the only way for someone from another root to reach that level is to convert and attach himself to Avraham's root. Even so, the nations have misvot, the seven Noahide laws, and a kind of neshamah, not like a Jewish soul, but certainly unlike an animal, which has only a nefesh (this will be explained in Part 3). By the Ramhal's approach they have a share in the World to Come if they keep the seven laws; by the Rambam's, Jews and non-Jews have equal ability, with Jews having a greater propensity because of their misvot.

On hashgahah: animals receive only general hashgahah; Israel receives personal hashgahah; and the nations are overseen through an intermediary, the sar, the heavenly representative of each nation. This is what is meant by the sar of Esav with whom Yaakov fought.

Doesn't Israel have a sar too?

A participant asked: we speak of Mikhael as the sar of Israel, so what is the difference? The Rabbi answered from the end of Part 1, Chapter 5, where we learned of the chain of descent (hishtalshelut). Even for Israel nothing happens in this world directly from Hashem; it would be too direct, too intimate, and must come through levels of devolution. But Mikhael only implements Hashem's instructions. For the nations, the sar is actually in charge of what happens. It is not that Hashem cannot pay attention to them. But what Israel wants is the direct connection, which is what Moshe Rabbenu prayed for when he asked that Hashem Himself go with the people.

Paragraph 9: the world depends on Israel's deeds

"Veulam..." Hashem arranged that everything depends on the actions of Israel. Whether the world is set right or damaged, whether His presence is revealed or hidden, depends on them. The actions of the nations do not increase or decrease Hashem's illumination of the world. All

they can do is improve or harm themselves, and strengthen or weaken their sar: when they do good they increase his power, when they do bad they decrease it.

The Rabbi noted that some people's sense that non-Jews lack value may stem from this paragraph, which he had addressed last class.

What does this mean for events in the news?

The Ramhal's idea echoes Hazal. The Hafes Hayim would say that whenever you hear something in the news, we are in some way responsible for it, and he made a point of following the news for that reason. But does that make sense? If a building collapses in China, or a plane crashes with a hundred non-Jews on board, what has it to do with us?

The Rabbi offered two ways of looking at it: - **The Hafes Hayim's way:** something happened because Jews did something wrong, or as a message or wake-up call for the Jewish people. A participant warned that this is dangerous to say, since people blame Jews for everything anyway. The Rabbi replied that perhaps, as global ambassadors, we do carry some responsibility. - **His own understanding, closer to the Rambam:** what depends on Israel is whether Hashem is involved in the world or hidden from it. But much in the world happens at random. Even within Israel, according to the Rambam, not all hashgahah is personal; it depends on a person living with Hashem. If people live without any connection to hashgahah, an engine failure is simply nature. "Not everything has to have a clear message." Where Jews are involved, he thinks there is more likely to be a message, because hashgahah is more direct.

The discussion went back and forth. A participant pointed out that small disasters happen every day in rural towns that no one in the West hears of. Another suggested that a particular event could also be a punishment specific to those people, perhaps for neglecting one of the seven laws. The Rabbi agreed that this is possible: "Maybe it's random, maybe it's a punishment... who knows?" His point was only that it is not necessarily because of what we did. He admitted he is uncomfortable speaking in these terms. A participant cited the Gemara that disasters come to the world because of judges who give wrong judgements; the Rabbi read it rationally: when judges, the pillars of society, fail to uphold law and order, society crumbles. Others noted that if we read bad events this way, we must also read good events as connected to us.

Hashgahah over the nations when it touches Israel

The Ramhal continues: Hashem does not oversee the nations in detail, except where it is relevant to Israel. Then He oversees even non-Jews closely. The Rabbi gave the example of an American president and American politics, which affect Israel. Rulers in any case receive special hashgahah, as will be learned. So too with people who behave in antisemitic ways: that is personal hashgahah directed at us, a message for us. He compared it to the sheep learned about months ago: a sheep has no individual hashgahah, but when it belongs to a Jew's flock, it does.

He drew out what he called a huge implication: in this view, a non-Jew's day-to-day life runs, for all intents and purposes, without hashgahah, apart from the limited involvement of his sar. Everything learned over the last two months about the reasons for suffering, gilgulim and so

on, does not apply in the same way. His share in the World to Come still depends on the seven Noahide laws.

Chapter 5: how Hashem oversees

Chapters 1 to 4 dealt with the technical laws of hashgahah: general and personal, how it works for Israel, and for the nations. Chapter 5 explains the manner in which Hashem oversees, in two parts: His perception (hashkafah) and His influence (hashpaah).

Hashem knows everything: past, present and future. Nothing is hidden from Him. So what does the Torah mean when it says "Vayashkef Hashem," Hashem looked down at Sedom, or looked at mankind to see if there was anyone wise? He knows all already. The Ramhal answers that "looking" means He now enters a mode of judgement, acting on what He has always known.

A participant asked whether this means Hashem checks that things went according to the script. The Rabbi said no. "It's wrong to think of God in those terms. There's no checking with HaKadosh Barukh Hu... He knows all. Finished." Next time: how His influence works, and where miracles fit in.

Summary

- Even Israel's sar, Mikhael, only implements Hashem's will; the sar of a nation actually directs its affairs.
- Paragraph 9: the revelation or concealment of Hashem in the world depends on Israel's actions; the nations affect only themselves and their sar.
- The Rabbi weighed the Hafes Hayim's view that world events carry a message for us against a view, closer to the Rambam, that much happens at random.
- Hashem oversees the nations closely where it touches Israel; antisemitism, for example, is a message for us.
- Chapter 5 begins: Hashem knows all, and "looking" in the Torah means turning to judgement, not checking.

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